

BAKER (BALDWIN) CEMETERY

According to The History of Monaca, 1840-1940, the Baker Cemetery is the oldest of cemeteries in the Borough of Monaca, founded in 1808 by Anthony Baker I. This historic cemetery is situated on a tract of land that was originally comprised of the Morris, Mellon, Baldwin and Ferguson Farms and is located approximately 100 yards south of 21st Street in Monaca, and lies between the overhead pass for Beaver Avenue at Route 51/Pennsylvania Avenue and the private entrance to the former Colonial Steel Company, currently at the southernmost end of the Moor Industrial Park.

Records at the Beaver County Court House indicate the Baldwin Family purchased this property in 1901-1902 for the purpose of building a railroad spur into the nearby territories. The Baker heirs went to court to obtain an injunction to keep the cemetery intact. The injunction was granted and it was decreed the cemetery must be included in the expansion plan.

The History of Monaca, 1840-1940 indicates there are "perhaps 50 graves" in the Baker Cemetery. In 1971, local county historian, Denver Walton completed a study and documented the presence of 67 black markers and headstones. In his notes, Mr. Walton remarked "It is extremely difficult to state whether or not all the stones listed as "black" mark graves. Most are worn down, some being very small while others do resemble gravestones very much. None of this color, with the exception of the George Holsinger grave is able to be read. All however, are planted, upright, in the manner of grave markers. None are merely pieces of stone lying on top of the ground". Mr. Walton further stated "None of the graves are actually set in a strict patterned row, but certain general patterns can be seen." The cemetery is comprised of seven rows of graves, with the first row designated as being closest to the railroad track and Pennsylvania Avenue, and the seventh row as being closest to the fence and road leading to the cemetery through the industrial park.

Three veterans' graves were noted in the Baker-Baldwin Cemetery, including Anthony Baker I who served in the Revolutionary War in Co. H., 39th Va. Regiment, Anthony Baker II, grandson of Anthony Baker I who served in the Civil War in Co. H., 139th Pa. Volunteer (Infantry) Division, and one unmarked grave in Row 4, believed to be that of a soldier by the name of Graham who is mentioned in the History of Monaca, 1840-1890 as being buried here..

The original cemetery was fenced in with and old style barbed wire. In 1971, Mr. Walton noted the wire was gone with the exception of a few rusty strands. The wooden posts were rotting and some had fallen. Mr. Bernard Catalucci of the Great Arrow Historical Society verified the fence had been replaced with a rustic split rail fence in the early 1970's. For many years, local boy scouts had maintained the cemetery.

In 2011, two volunteers from the *Monaca Volunteer Community Outreach*, a division of the Ohio River Trail Council, were made aware of the deterioration of the cemetery. Virginia (Frank) Korak and Patricia (Reskovac) Majors accomplished a full restoration of the cemetery by pruning low tree limbs and removing overgrown brush and grape vines that obscured several of

the grave markers and headstones. Fallen headstones were uprighted and shrubs were trimmed. Additional volunteer labor was offered by Borough Manager Mario Leone, the Lawson Family of Rock Concrete, and Evan Pierce. A new split rail fence was donated by Virginia Korak with the assistance of Lowe's Home Improvement Store managers Albert Antoline and Ryan Frantz. Installation services were donated by Christopher McKenzie. Today, the Baker-Baldwin Cemetery has been restored and very much resembles the original cemetery of 1808.

REFERENCES:

1. The History of Monaca, 1840-1940
2. Great Arrow Historical Association, Mr. Bernard Catalucci
3. "Old Baker Cemetery" Saved in 1901 by a Court Injunction", by Grace Swick, North Edition, January 18, 1973
4. Mr. Denver Walton, research notes
5. Mrs. Annie Barto McCartney, great-great granddaughter of Anthony Baker, Baker Family History